Earned Media Playbook

RetailzPOS / Vitreous Alliance · Patel Processing — Forbes, CNN, USA Today, NerdWallet, Fit Small Business, CNBC · October 2026

The honest bottom line, up front

These six outlets split into three very different categories, and the right move is different for each:

1. **Fully controllable, low/no cost, realistic now:** journalist query platforms (HARO/Qwoted/Featured), original survey-based content, and the CNBC fintech-list nomination when it reopens.
2. **Controllable, but requires a budget decision:** NerdWallet / Fit Small Business / Forbes Advisor placement (these are **paid affiliate partnerships, not press pitches**) and Forbes Councils membership (paid, vetted, but yields real bylined Forbes.com content).
3. **Essentially out of direct control, needs a genuine news hook:** organic CNN Business, CNBC Small Business Playbook, or USA Today news coverage. These follow actual newsworthiness — a notable funding round, a notable data trend, a regulatory fight — more than any pitch technique.

The biggest thing to get right mentally: **“get mentioned on NerdWallet” and “get mentioned on CNN” are not the same kind of project.** One is a business-development conversation about a paid partnership. The other is closer to a lottery ticket that only pays off with a real news hook. The plan below treats them accordingly.

Outlet by outlet

NerdWallet

NerdWallet’s “best POS systems” / “best credit card processors” roundups are a **pay-to-be-featured affiliate model**, not an open editorial pick. NerdWallet publicly states it works with 30+ partners who have a commercial agreement and pay a referral/click fee to appear. Its own methodology page says data for the comparison tables comes “from the provider’s public-facing website and from company representatives” — so a company can become a data source, but a slot in the ranked table runs through a paid partnership.

Realistic path: contact NerdWallet's business/partnerships team about becoming an affiliate partner in the POS or merchant-services vertical. This is a business-development conversation, not a press pitch — and it costs money (a referral fee per signup/click, not a flat fee).

Fit Small Business

Owned by TechnologyAdvice since 2022. Same pattern as NerdWallet: a public "Our Partners" page, revenue mainly from commissions on featured products, and language about "continuously adding new partners." No public vendor-submission form was found.

Realistic path: reach out to TechnologyAdvice's advertising/partnerships team directly (not an editor) about becoming a featured partner in the credit-card-processing or POS comparison content. Again, a paid B2B deal, not earned coverage.

Forbes

Three distinct doors, very different odds:

1. **Forbes Advisor** (the "best POS/best processor" vertical) — an affiliate-revenue operation like NerdWallet/Fit Small Business, with a disclosure that "advertisers pay for their offers to be shown." Same playbook: pursue as a paid affiliate/advertiser relationship.
2. **Forbes Councils** (Business Council, Finance Council, etc.) — a **paid, vetted membership** (third-party estimates put it roughly $1,500–$5,000/year depending on council; not confirmed on Forbes' own current pricing page), with eligibility criteria like "$500K+ annual revenue" for the Business Council. Members can publish bylined articles directly on Forbes.com and appear in Expert Panels. **This is the most realistic earned-content path onto Forbes.com for a company this size** — it's pay-to-apply with a real vetting step, not pay-to-publish outright.
3. **Forbes staff journalists** — reachable the normal way, through journalist query platforms or direct pitching to reporters covering small-business fintech/payments. Free, but odds are low without a genuine news hook.

CNBC

No vendor-submission process exists for general coverage — staff reporters own their beats and pitch their own stories. The one concrete, applicable door: **CNBC's annual "World's Top Fintech Companies" list (with Statista)**, which runs an open, no-cost nomination window (the 2024 cycle ran Feb 29–Apr 24 via a Statista-hosted form; applicants select their market category and list competitors; contact was

topfintechs@statista.com). **Worth calendaring to check for a 2027 nomination window opening.**

Beyond that, CNBC Small Business Playbook and CNBC Select coverage run through staff reporters/producers, pitched like any journalist (via query platforms or direct outreach) — no special small-vendor intake exists.

USA Today

Two very different tracks:

1. USA Today's **licensed finance/"best of" content** runs on the Red Ventures/ affiliate-publishing model (the same company behind Bankrate) — not pitchable directly by a vendor; it's an affiliate-advertiser relationship managed at the publisher level.
2. USA Today's own small-business journalism is pitchable the normal journalist way, but no current editor contact or submission channel was confirmed in research — would need to identify the current Money/Small Business editor directly on usatoday.com.

CNN

CNN Underscored (the product-review/affiliate site) is staffed by dedicated writers who, per a job posting found, "communicate with manufacturers and press relations agencies to obtain products" for testing — meaning PR outreach to Underscored's team is a real channel, though no public pitch guidelines were found. Best practice (borrowed from comparable sites like Wirecutter): ask a specific writer if they want a sample before sending one unsolicited.

CNN Business (actual news coverage) is pitched like any outlet — reporter by reporter, and needs a genuine news angle. Not something to expect on demand.

Cross-cutting tactics that apply across all six

Journalist query platforms — the most realistic, lowest-cost lever available right now

- **HARO** is back as a free, email-based service after Featured.com relaunched it in April 2025 (Cision's paid "Connectively" rebrand shut down Dec 2024). Three digests a day, no login, no pitch limit, free.
- **Qwoted** — a free tier (limited responses) plus a paid Pro tier (roughly $99/mo per third-party estimates), aimed at higher-authority business/finance outlets with less noise than HARO's firehose.
- **Featured.com** — a Q&A marketplace, free tier plus paid plans (roughly $49/mo), syndicates expert answers to partner publishers.
- Realistic expectation: a **5–15% pitch success rate**, and speed matters — popular queries draw hundreds of responses within the first hour.

Practical use for RetailzPOS/Patel Processing: whoever fills the Content Specialist role (see the hiring proposal already in progress) monitors these daily for queries tagged fintech, payments, small business, POS, retail compliance, or merchant cash advance, and responds fast with specific, quotable expertise — a useful answer that happens to carry a name, title, and company, not a pitch for the company.

Press release wire distribution — overrated for press pickup, useful for other reasons

Enterprise wires (PR Newswire, roughly $350 + $295 membership; Business Wire, roughly $800/release) are built for investor-relations/compliance disclosure, not earned coverage — journalists increasingly ignore bulk distributions. Budget wires (EIN Presswire ~$149, PRWeb ~$110) mainly buy Google News/Bing News indexing and a backlink, not CNBC coverage.

Bottom line: a wire release is worth it for SEO/searchability and a dated public record — for example, a Patel Processing rebrand announcement — not as a strategy to land on Forbes or CNN.

Original survey/data content — the strongest lever fully within our control

Journalists actively look for original data to cite. A well-designed survey becomes the thing a reporter links to or quotes, rather than something that has to be begged out of an editor. A realistic version for RetailzPOS specifically: survey a sample of convenience-store/liquor-store/smoke-shop owners on something timely — ID-check compliance habits, holiday staffing, cash-flow stress, loyalty-program usage — and publish the results as a short report, pitched alongside relevant HARO/Qwoted queries and directly to reporters covering small-business retail trends.

This is a natural extension of work already underway this session (the daily trend briefs, the compliance-focused blog content) — not a new skill to acquire, just a new output format.

Awards — a mixed bag, worth sorting by type

- **Newsweek Readers' Choice** — editorially curated, not a submission process; businesses can't pay or trade services to be listed, and nominees are chosen by Newsweek's own panel. Not directly applicable here.
- **CNBC's World's Top Fintech Companies (with Statista)** — genuinely open, no-cost nomination window (details above). Worth calendaring for 2027.
- **Industry-specific awards** (e.g., card & payments industry awards) exist with real submission/shortlist processes, but run on their own annual cycles — worth tracking the organizer's site directly for the next call for entries.

PR agency / freelancer cost reality, if this is ever budgeted

Freelance PR retainers run roughly $2,000–$5,000/month; boutique agencies roughly $3,500–$10,000/month (US estimates from PR-industry pricing guides, not independently verified for this report). A real cost center, not a near-term plan without a dedicated budget line.

Suggested next steps

1. **Start now, free:** have the (soon-to-be-hired) Content Specialist set up HARO and a Qwoted free account, and build a 10-minute daily habit of scanning for relevant queries.
2. **Plan a first survey-based report:** pick one timely, compliance-adjacent topic (holiday staffing stress, ID-check habits, cash-flow concerns heading into Q1) and scope a short merchant survey RetailzPOS/Moolah Points can run through its own customer base — this becomes both a pitchable data asset and standalone blog/LinkedIn content.
3. **Make a budget decision, not a PR decision:** NerdWallet, Fit Small Business, and Forbes Advisor placements are advertiser conversations — worth a direct outreach to each site's partnerships team to get real current pricing before deciding whether it's worth it.
4. **Evaluate Forbes Councils** as a mid-term option once revenue eligibility and the current membership fee are confirmed directly with Forbes — this is the most realistic path to an actual Forbes.com byline.
5. **Calendar the CNBC fintech-list nomination window** to check when it reopens for 2027 (it's free and genuinely open).
6. **Treat CNN/CNBC/USA Today organic news coverage as a byproduct, not a target** — the survey-based content and any genuine news hook (a notable milestone, a regulatory fight RetailzPOS is positioned to comment on) are what would actually earn that kind of pickup, not direct outreach alone.

Research basis: current (2026) public information on each outlet's editorial/affiliate structure, journalist query platforms, and press-distribution services, gathered via web search. Several specifics — USA Today's current Money-section editor contact, exact current Forbes Councils pricing, and whether NerdWallet/Fit Small Business maintain a formal advertiser-inquiry form — weren't confirmable from public search and would need direct outreach to each publisher's advertising/partnerships team to pin down before committing budget.